This is perhaps nowhere more apparent than in the collection of core string functions. They vary in naming convention, parameter handling, and error emission. A lot of the function names are quite confusingly similar, and multiple similarly named functions exist where perhaps a better design might have been a single function with extra parameters. For example, `strpos()` is used to search strings for sub-strings, but there also exist `stripos()`, `strrpos()`, and `strripos()`, which are case-insensitive and reverse direction forms. An alternative design might be `strpos($direction, $case_sensitive, ...$args)` as a way to reduce cognitive load on the programmer, and some of the string functions do have these features. It is also the case that a small number of functions also have aliases (alternative names). I can only apologize.

I have (roughly) sorted the string handling functions into six categories, given in the table below with example use cases. Note that regular expression functions (which would neatly slot into the "Comparison" and "Extraction" categories) are omitted here and will have their own dedicated section following this one (something for you to look forward to). We'll also close out the chapter with a look at other string extensions in PHP (including those for cryptography).

- **Comparison and Analysis** – Collation, character/sub-string counts, phonetic analysis.
- **Conversion and Extraction** – Fetch sub-strings, create arrays of sub-strings or tokens, get/set byte values.
- **Encoding and Escaping** – Add/remove slashes, handle HTML, injection attack protection.
- **Formatting and Transformation** – Change case, add/remove spaces or newlines, interpolate values, substitute portions of strings, and more.
- **Hashing and Error Checking** – Compute hash value, e.g., CRC32, MD5.

The goal of this section (which, to be honest, could have been a chapter in its own right) is to present the core string functions of the language. There are also some very frequently used language extensions (such as `mbstring`, `iconv`, `intl`, and `hash`) that introduce their own functions to the global scope, and we'll certainly cover some of these in an upcoming section. That said, the aim of this chapter has been to impress on you, dear reader, the pitfalls of confusing PHP's string data type with human language,